

blueberries into juice, and calcium into hot cocoa. Many of these foods can be viewed as “new and improved.” Others are just exploiting the same benefits they (and other brands) have always offered.

#### 4. Animals are friends

As consumers demand to know exactly where their food is coming from, meats, eggs, and dairy will hold a new spotlight. Foods from “humane” sources are in high demand, and with that comes a higher price. Consumers need to have an understanding of how standards are applied, however, before they can assume that pricier foods will meet their ethical standards. Eggs, for example, can carry the label “cage-free,” “free-range,” or “certified organic” and still not be “certified humane.” For details on what each label means, the Humane Society of the United States ([www.HSUS.org](http://www.HSUS.org)). If you’re going to be paying three times more for that egg, it’s good to know if it will actually meet your standards.

#### 5. It’s all included

New breakfast kits, lunch kits, and snack packs are hitting store shelves every week. Some of them include everything you need for a healthy meal (or so it seems). In addition to



being calorie-rich and preservative-laden, many of them are also missing some key components. Several complete cereal packages are an attempt to give kids a healthy start to their day. While a great idea in theory, it seems disappointing that parents can’t even get it together enough to pour a bowl of cold cereal and throw down a glass of juice for Junior. And did anyone else notice that these “complete breakfasts” are missing the milk? (I won’t even address the horrendous amount of packaging this product comes in.)

As marketing companies struggle to come up with new ways to sell you the same food, be aware of trends that become widespread over several brands. With markups at over 200% of the cheapest brands, it may be wise to do a little additional research before succumbing to the temptation to buy. Generally speaking, the more advertising money a company has thrown at a new product, the more they are going to charge—and consequently, the more they *need* you to